

Supporting Details - Study Guide

Choose the detail that gives the strongest direct support - not merely a detail about the same topic.

Learning goal

Match a claim or idea to the strongest evidence in the passage, especially when more than one option is relevant.

1. What counts as support?

Detail type	What it does	Example
Direct support	Provides evidence for the exact idea	Attendance rose 18% after evening hours were added.
Related detail	Shares the topic but proves something else	The library opened in 1986.
Background	Provides context without proving the target idea	The library serves three neighborhoods.

2. How exam-style questions ask it

- Which detail best supports the idea that ___?
- Which sentence provides the strongest support for ___?
- Which detail most clearly shows that ___?

3. The four-step method

1. **Restate the idea.** Put the target claim in your own words.
2. **Predict the evidence.** What kind of fact would actually prove or explain it?

3. **Compare every option to that exact idea.** A true sentence is not automatically useful evidence.
4. **Choose the strongest direct support.** Prefer evidence that requires the least extra assumption.

4. Strongest support vs. some support

Harder questions may give you two choices that both help.

The better answer is usually more specific, more direct, or more clearly connected to the exact claim.

Claim: The new evening schedule increased participation.

Choice A: Several visitors said they preferred evening hours.

Choice B: Average attendance rose from 27 to 61 people after the evening schedule began.

Both are relevant. B is stronger because it directly measures participation.

5. Long-passage strategy

Find the claim in the question first. Then scan the passage for evidence that matches the **same relationship**. Do not collect every sentence about the same topic.

If the claim contains two parts, the strongest evidence may need to support both parts.

6. Common traps

Trap	Why it fails
Mentioned, but not supportive	The detail appears in the passage but does not prove the target idea.

Weak indirect support	It points in the right direction, but another option is more direct.
Evidence for another point	The sentence is useful evidence, just not for this claim.
Contradictory detail	The option actually weakens the target idea.

7. Worked example

A town installed shaded bus shelters at six heavily used stops. Before the change, riders often waited in direct sun during summer afternoons. A survey two months later found that riders at the upgraded stops were more likely to rate the wait as comfortable, even though bus arrival times had not changed.

Which detail best supports the idea that the shelters improved riders' experience without changing the schedule?

- A. Six stops were upgraded.
- B. Riders had previously waited in direct sun.
- C. Riders rated the wait as more comfortable even though arrival times stayed the same.
- D. The survey was taken two months later.

Best answer: C. It supports both parts of the idea: better comfort and unchanged arrival times.

8. Diagnostic help

- **You choose details just because they contain the same keywords:** restate what the detail must prove.
- **You miss "strongest" questions:** compare directness and specificity between the final two options.

- **You choose evidence for another point:** say the target claim aloud before looking back at the passage.

9. Quick check

A school added a weekend garden program. In the first month, 64 students volunteered for Saturday planting sessions. The garden also includes herbs, tomatoes, and native flowers behind the science building.

Which detail best supports the idea that the project increased student participation outside regular class time?

- A. The garden contains native flowers.
- B. The garden is behind the science building.
- C. Sixty-four students volunteered for Saturday sessions.
- D. Tomatoes are grown in the garden.

Answer: C. It directly shows students participating on weekends.

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